A.R. Rahman: The Genius Who Took Indian Music Global | Nikhil Kamath | People by WTF | Ep 15

(0:23 - 0:52)

This compared to this profile shot. This is the final stage. Hi, how are you? Thank you.

(0:54 - 0:59)

Okay. She was telling me earlier. Put you under the bus.

(1:00 - 1:17)

She doesn't speak much. You also don't speak much. I told you, right? I predicted, right? When you speak Tamil, I can understand it.

(1:17 - 1:23)

Because I'm also a South Indian. Oh. And I've grown up all my life in Bangalore.

(1:23 - 1:25)

Bangalore. So, Kannadiga. Kannadiga.

(1:25 - 1:33)

Half Kannadiga, half Konkani. Dad is from this town near Udupi called Udyavar. And mom is from Mysore.

(1:33 - 1:39)

Have you been to Bangalore much? Yeah, yeah. 80s. Yeah? Quite a lot.

(1:39 - 1:49)

Used to work for Kannada industry a little bit. So, how is the Kannada industry? Kannada industry is now rocking, right? There was a dormant 20 years. Nothing happened.

(1:49 - 1:55)

After the grades. Now they just leaped. I met, I sometimes wish all of them.

(1:56 - 2:04)

I call them on Zoom and wish. They're doing much better. The Kannada music composer, Rishabh and everybody.

(2:05 - 2:16)

So, you grew up in Chennai? Most of your life has been in Chennai? Most of the life in Chennai. Yeah, I was born in Chennai. My father, yes, he used to work in the studios.

(2:16 - 2:23)

And then we are in the belly of the beast near Kodambakkam. Okay. Our house, where all the studios used to exist.

(2:24 - 2:37)

So, maybe we start by making you a little bit awkward and getting you to speak about your life so far. Everybody knows you. And I'm a fan.

(2:37 - 2:43)

I've heard so many of your songs from different eras. And I love them. I wish I could sing better.

(2:44 - 2:50)

And then I would have, but I can't. My mother used to be a music teacher. Classical Carnatic music.

(2:51 - 3:08)

And they tried to teach us everything. So, I went to classes for guitar, piano, flute, mandolin, everything. But I discovered after much effort that I have zero talent.

(3:09 - 3:13)

No, it's not about talent. It's about leaning in. Never give up.

(3:18 - 3:27)

Tell us a bit about your childhood. It feels like you're a... From what I've heard, you're very introverted. Yeah.

(3:27 - 3:48)

And now you're more open to speaking because as you have said, your ability to articulate has gone up significantly. What changed? I think when I was growing up, I went through all this. The death of my father, my grandmother.

(3:49 - 4:06)

And then conflicts where I was just seeing trauma every day. My mother was a single, very, very confident lady. She took all the pain.

(4:06 - 4:26)

At what age did that pass away? Nine. And she had to go through protect us from... And she was so strong that withstanding all the kind of humiliations, she single-handedly brought us up, right? Encouraging me to go into music. She decided for me that I should be in music.

(4:26 - 4:37)

So, I've told that many times. And so, in a way, I felt like I should be clean. Because I had three sisters.

(4:39 - 5:00)

And me behaving in a certain way would also reflect what's coming back. And I was... My whole childhood was with 40-year-old and 50-year-old, 60-year-old in the studio playing music. And I missed all the fun with friends and all that stuff at school.

(5:01 - 5:14)

No college. What year did you stop going to school? 15, 16. Same.

Actually, me also. You also? School is not just about education. It's about understanding humanity.

(5:14 - 5:23)

It's about seeing each other and getting to know the stories. And learning things from other kids. Their families are different.

(5:26 - 5:31)

That I missed. Definitely. But then I got the... I was with intelligent people in the studio.

(5:31 - 5:38)

Great musicians in the studio. Which also inspired me to reach up to more musicality. And play more stuff.

(5:39 - 5:47)

Your dad was a successful... He was. So, the story is like... Dad lived in his house. Father-mother's house.

(5:48 - 5:57)

And both mom and dad... Their clothes were thrown onto the streets. Said, get out of this house. From his family members.

(5:58 - 6:07)

So, he had to go search for a house. So, he took a rented house. And then to get us a house... He worked day and night.

(6:08 - 6:24)

Worked in three different places at the same time. So, that one story is that... His health went bad. Because he... Anyway, that's the dark side of my childhood memory.

(6:24 - 6:29)

That's why I never speak about my dad. You have vivid memories of this age, right? Yeah. Yeah.

(6:30 - 6:47)

I think after that... To forget what the trauma... Took ages, right? And has that memory changed? Now it's changed. Because I think... It was such an inspiration. Because every musician... Came from his troupe.

(6:48 - 6:55)

Whether it's a guitarist, a violin player or... Because he had given so much work to the musicians. Because he was working in different places. And everybody used to adore him.

(6:56 - 7:00)

Even if they're not talented... But then you sit in the last row. Take some money and go. It'll be good for your family.

(7:01 - 7:10)

Good for your education. Even people like... World class players like El Subramaniam... Had kind words to say. He shared with me a couple of years back.

(7:11 - 7:18)

So, even now, even today... That probably set the standard for me. To where I should head. As a human being.

(7:18 - 7:26)

As a successor to him. And now my nephew... GV Prakash is shining. He won the national award twice.

(7:26 - 7:31)

He's a hero. And my son. My daughters.

(7:32 - 7:48)

And how did that change you? My dad passed away recently. Last year. How does it affect you first? And how does it change you later? It affects you because... That's the only thing you... You have, right? Your parents.

(7:50 - 7:57)

That's the only holding ground for you. The memories and what your dad... That's what he represented. Or how he worked.

(7:59 - 8:10)

And... So, to everyone... Your dad is your first hero. Right? Your mother is the angel. Who... Was a safe place to go.

(8:11 - 8:19)

The lap is the safe place to sleep. And... That's why the respect for my mother... Or my father is still there. Same thing.

(8:20 - 8:36)

So... Did the position of your mother... In your head change... After your father's demise? Yeah, my mother became like an entrepreneur. She took the equipments... And started renting it out. Everybody suggested that she should... Sell all the stuff.

(8:36 - 8:42)

Put it in the bank. Get the interest. She said, no, no.

My son will play. I'll keep my husband's stuff. And then she expanded it.

(8:42 - 8:47)

She bought more keyboards for rental. Used to rent it out for light music. For studios.

(8:48 - 8:53)

So that was the income for like 6-7 years. And then that stopped. Because everybody started buying the equipments.

(8:53 - 8:59)

That's when she said, now it's not going to happen. You need to go and play. The equipment rental has gone down.

(9:00 - 9:10)

And you started writing jingles? No, I started playing keyboards for other composers. Yeah? Like Telugu composers, Kannada composers. Mr. L.A. Raja, T. Rajendra, M. S. Sri.

(9:11 - 9:15)

Raj Koti. Multiple composers. Every day there are two songs.

(9:16 - 9:28)

Every day there will be like... I go at 9, I come back at 10. And do they tell you what to play? Or do you have to come up with it? They'll give the notes. But after a while, I think when I... Bought my computer systems.

(9:29 - 9:34)

Which is around 86. They gave me the freedom. They'll just give me the melody.

(9:34 - 9:39)

And I'll say, you arrange it. So I'd arrange all the stuff for them. So that, I got used to arrangement.

(9:40 - 9:48)

It was easier for me to arrange then. They'll say, okay, just do a fight music. So I'll have to create a fight music.

(9:48 - 10:09)

With rhythm and... Large tootie bangs. And stuff like that. If you could pick one instrument... And never play another again, which one would it be? Yeah, I know.

Maybe. Yeah? It's hard to travel with, right? It is. Like a guitar, you can just carry.

(10:10 - 10:21)

No, but keyboard is like... You can have a smaller one. The electronic one. But having a piano, I could only afford... After probably... 6-7 years of my learning.

(10:22 - 10:30)

Then I bought a Yamaha. Then now I have... Steinway and all the stuff. So for a few years, you played... With other composers.

(10:31 - 10:40)

Almost 10 years. And then, they started first telling you... What you should play and then allowing you... Your own compositions or arrangement. Yeah.

(10:40 - 10:49)

And then slowly went into jingles. Which everything is mine. But jingles, you mean ads, right? Ads, yeah.

(10:50 - 11:00)

Like in Tamil? No, I think jingles because... Most of the agencies are international agencies. Like O&M, HTA. They would do the scratches here.

(11:00 - 11:07)

And they will throw that out... And do it in Mumbai. And then after a time, I think... They started agreeing. They started putting out my stuff.

(11:08 - 11:21)

Initially it was scratches. What is a scratch? Scratch is a tune where they just give it to the... Client to say... If it's an ointment... Or a paint. And they say, okay, this will work.

(11:22 - 11:31)

Now go to a bigger jingle composer... And get this. So then that became like, okay, now... This itself is good enough and we can use it. So that's the process.

(11:33 - 11:44)

When did it all change? When was that? 1991. I know, actually... Magic happened when I built my studio. It was an 89 Panchatan studio which I have.

(11:45 - 11:50)

It was when I felt empowered. Like I had something which nobody had. Which was? My home

studio.

(11:52 - 12:09)

Why did that change so much? Many people probably had access to a studio, right? Those days, studios means like... The big halls where... 90 people can play together. The concept of home studio never came. So when I built my home studio... It was when I realized like... Nobody will judge me.

(12:09 - 12:17)

Whether I do good music or bad music. I can judge it myself and play the final product. Because in studios, whatever you play... 50 other people are watching you.

(12:18 - 12:45)

If you... If you're bringing equipment, they're all coming. What is the new stuff? How many people are going to lose jobs? So I was the... Gizmo guy, right? I used to buy the computers. So if I want to become a musician... In my life... Or if people watching... Want to become a musician... What is that thing they have to do now? Like you got a studio.

Is there some equivalent for today? You just have to practice. You just have an intention to learn. You can learn anywhere now.

(12:45 - 12:57)

What if I'm already learned? Not me because I have no knowledge but... Somebody who is a learned, trained musician. You come to Chennai, come to my conservatory... It's called K Music Conservatory. Right.

(12:57 - 13:12)

And there you will teach me how to compose music? Everything. Any course. Like piano, voice and... Okay.

So you started a studio at home. And then? And then I started experimenting with my own music. Which nobody heard.

(13:12 - 13:20)

Mani Ratnam came and I played them all. And he was quietly listening to all the stuff. That listening session... Became the DNA for Roja.

(13:21 - 13:32)

Yeah. And then Roja changed everything. Immediately? Yeah.

Overnight. Yeah? What year was this? 91 I think. Right.

(13:33 - 13:39)

So Roja released and next day... Roja released. People started treating you differently. All together.

(13:40 - 13:45)

Yeah. Because he is one of the top directors. Every actor, every composer wanted to work with him.

(13:45 - 13:54)

Right. He is one of the top. Not still.

I feel like... Everybody is drooling over to work with Mani Ratnam. Whether it is a success or not. Even the process is so respectful.

(13:55 - 14:02)

The same is true for you. You know that. Yeah.

Absolutely. Okay. And then everything changed.

(14:03 - 14:09)

People around you treated you changed. How did you change? How did I change? I was like... Okay. This will be the last movie.

(14:10 - 14:12)

I don't want this. I don't want movies. Because I have been in movies.

(14:13 - 14:18)

And it's so boring. But the Mani Ratnam movies are completely different. And he kind of listened to me.

(14:18 - 14:24)

Like this is what I want to do. Or I don't want to do movies. Then I told him like... I said I am very satisfied working with you.

(14:24 - 14:29)

I don't want to work with other people. He said no, no, no. You should work with everyone.

(14:30 - 14:35)

So I said I am very happy working just with you. And I will do jingles. Or I will do private albums.

(14:35 - 14:48)

He said no, you should work with everyone. So my first 10 years was like... Okay. Enough.

After this movie, I will leave everything. I will do my own stuff. Even movie was my own stuff.

(14:48 - 14:54)

But I have something non-film. Why do you think that was? I don't know why. I had this thing of leaving everything.

(14:54 - 15:07)

Is that because fear of disappointment? No, no. I was resisting... I was resisting the way the movie industry was consuming. Because my father was consumed.

(15:07 - 15:17)

Right? After he passed away, only couple of people were there. And nobody else showed up. So that's when I was like... People have their own lives.

(15:17 - 15:22)

Then you realize they all have their own lives. You were thinking this high will go away. Not the high.

(15:22 - 15:29)

It is a thankless. Any industry, it's not a community. We just meet in studios.

(15:30 - 16:09)

Very rarely do musicians meet. So after he passed away, it is not a government job. There is no pension.

Nothing. Musician job. I said if they are like that, we also have to be careful in not giving every part of us to the industry.

We should have soul left with us so that I can do other things in art. Do you still feel that way about movies? I always... That's one of the reasons why when other composers were doing 30

movies a year, I felt I would do 2. I started with 2 and then 3 and then 4. Then it became 12. Then I escaped to resist people coming to me.

(16:10 - 16:23)

I went to England and sat with Andrew Lloyd Webber doing Bombay Dreams. The reason is to resist and grow. I'm giving away all the stuff I learned but I don't have anything new to offer.

(16:23 - 16:36)

I'll be thrown away. It's important to evolve artistically as a musician, composer. It's when I think the foundation of what I'm doing now is probably my time in London, my time in Hollywood.

(16:37 - 16:41)

Not doing music. Studying. Going for short courses.

(16:44 - 16:52)

Unconnected with music but to understand art in a very different way. That's crazy that you're still learning to this day. Learning in a way because you're forced to learn.

(16:52 - 17:03)

You buy a new rhythm machine, you have to learn where to project load. Most of them are common. Even there many stuff is changing.

(17:04 - 18:15)

There's granular synthesis, there's algorithmic composition, there's AI assisted editing. Arrangements which all the masters have done like Bernstein and Gershwin and John Williams. It's fascinating to see the older Tchaikovsky Mozart and there's always things to learn.

Not to copy but to understand to speed up your orchestration. And even studying songs about poetry, about metaphoricness, about not straight words but where it's hitting you. Did you feel any imposter complex in this period where you thought you were undeserving of what you got? Always.

That's why I surrender. Does this also translate into personal life where you might spend a lot less money than you can afford to? Like what? Like say as a very wealthy man you can afford to live X lifestyle but you live 10% of that or 20% of that. My son is listening there.

(18:16 - 18:40)

I think because it's not that I'm not I feel like if I can sustain like my mother God bless her she used to give on Friday she used to give food. So doing one thing and for certain number of

people she used to feed them. We're still doing that.

(18:41 - 19:00)

She didn't feed on every day and on a bad situation you cut all the stuff. We're able to do that by the grace of God even now. That's consistently doing something good for a long time is better than doing everything at the one time and then not having money.

(19:00 - 19:15)

So I believe that consistency is very important. Your lifestyle even whether you have money or not can be the same. Because when I was doing Roja I didn't have money for even putting petrol because I was just doing that one movie because I concentrated so much.

(19:15 - 19:36)

The days where I didn't have my petrol was, I used to drive that time was zero. And I felt like it's a good feeling because you're sacrificing all that stuff for the believing in what you're doing. So it's important that even my children realize like to be consistently in one lifestyle.

(19:36 - 20:02)

You can travel, you can eat anywhere you want but you don't you don't want to show the whole world what you are. And then it's a fake pompousness, right? And anyway in Chennai I think it's a city which makes you be simple. It's not unlike some other places where they don't hug you and see what you're wearing.

(20:05 - 20:49)

I would ask myself when I, like Delhi and Hyderabad are on one side and Bangalore and Chennai are on the other side of where projections sit. So I would think why is it appealing to Bangalore and Chennai to live under their means and why is the opposite, the whole showing living in the moment more appealing to the North? No, nothing wrong. I think it's the way I think is consistency over years rather than, you know, you can buy the best car, you can buy a Bugatti you can be in the best flat but then ultimately where do you get the happiness? In the studio.

(20:50 - 21:12)

So if you look at my studio, I have the most expensive piano, the most expensive mixer but that's again helping me to serve better. Right? So it's a little old school but I believe it. When I thought about this, I was thinking about things like okay, maybe North India saw so much war, so many people invaded.

(21:14 - 21:47)

People did not live for as long, so they live more in the moment. People in the South have largely been secure for a long period of time. Nobody is secure.

Relatively. They have other tortures in life. It is a double edged sword.

When we go out it's important to present India in the best possible way. Because the whole world thinks India is in poverty and this and that. I feel like India certain people are not in poverty.

(21:47 - 22:00)

We probably have the richest Indians here. And it's important to represent the country with dignity to dress up, to show that we are cultured people, we have a great history and culture and style and everything. It's very, very important.

(22:00 - 22:10)

You don't want to show them that it's very simple when people are judging you. As an Indian, I feel like I want to be the best representative. The best car outside.

(22:10 - 22:18)

When I go and I'm in LA, I have a Bentley. I lease a Bentley. I mean at least I had that time.

(22:20 - 23:17)

Why a Bentley van? Because it's easy. It's cheaper. You have to pay 110% duty here and there.

You just lease. You can get any car. As an artist, the style aesthetic of Bentley appeals most? Not like that.

Because I never believed in that and because it was so cheap there to rent any car. I had that moment of two years driving my kids around. Hey, come let's go.

And I have still videos of my son screaming when I'm going fast. Sitting in the back. And you started driving when you were really early and still enjoy driving? You still drive? I do drive.

I started driving again. I got my Mahindra electric car. And there I have Why Mahindra electric car? I don't know.

I just love it. For the first time I felt like it's world class quality. I also worked on it.

I was also constantly suggesting them do this do that. The sound system some of the best. My music sounds the best in that.

(23:18 - 23:23)

Then the car. So you're part of the design? I'm not getting paid for this. It's okay guys.

(23:24 - 23:37)

So it was like a hobby project? It was something very different. I think Hans Zimmer had done for BMW. And Mr. Velu who was the CEO, he came in and we had fun.

(23:41 - 24:11)

And beyond Roja and the initial success, what happened after that? Also were you in some way on the cusp of a change in trend of what kind of music was working in India in the 90s? Did you catch a change in trend? Or did you create a change in trend? The trend happened because of Roja. There was a denial that this won't last. What was the incumbent trend and what was the change in trend? There was this traditional kind of music which is beautiful.

(24:13 - 24:20)

The Hindi composers were all there. There's a beauty in it still. Because I'm not made of that.

(24:22 - 24:31)

My sensibility was different. Because I was in a band. I like jazz.

I like rock. I like Kavali. I like Carnatic.

(24:31 - 24:43)

I like Hindustani. So my aspiration was very expansive. I didn't want to stick to that Dholak and Mandolin kind of this thing.

(24:43 - 24:53)

I wanted to... Because I could do it. I was now experienced in arranging for other people and also seeing the results. I had my own studio.

(24:54 - 25:04)

And I could get to the results faster than imagining it. Without people judging me. So you changed that trend into Roja kind of music.

(25:04 - 25:39)

How would you articulate that? What was Roja kind of music? Roja was very... So my intention was when I met Maniratnamji, I said when we are listening to Pink Floyd, Queen, John Williams, Evangelus, Beatles, Michael Jackson, they don't listen to us. So what's the reason? Language, production and vibe, feel, recording. Multiple things.

(25:40 - 25:44)

Right? So I addressed all the stuff. I was studying all the stuff. Addressed all the stuff.

(25:45 - 26:28)

I said Tamil song which we do here should go If you look at my initial interviews, it says each Tamil song I do should go around the world. And it was planned. I worked for it.

That's why I did less work. And I had to... A lot of people thought okay this guy is like very adamant and snobbish. Not.

My human limitations are I need time to heal. I need time to listen to it. I need time to change.

I need to evolve a song into what present shape. It's not like I could do a song 3 songs in 7 hours because I knew all the formulas. That's not what I wanted to do.

(26:28 - 26:55)

I wanted to take it inch by inch to what I felt would be the future of my song for the world. Indian classical music never had its day under the sun per se. Like at some point, rock music was cool.

At some point, jazz was cool. At some point, I'm saying across the world. In India obviously Bollywood is very very popular.

(26:56 - 27:02)

We need to position classical music in a very higher way. I think right now it's like I give this much money, I can get a teacher. No.

(27:03 - 27:16)

Getting a good teacher getting the... transfer of knowledge. Mind to mind transfer. Not just the knowledge of ragas but the spirit of giving from a guru.

(27:17 - 27:25)

Only India sees that. It comes in the saints and the Sufis. It's not just knowledge.

(27:26 - 27:36)

It's giving the prayer and the soul actually wishes something and manifests. The product has to be truthful. The product has to be sincere.

(27:37 - 27:50)

When it's sincere, they grab it. Because if you look at all the voice talent shows, they pick the best compositions usually. Because it's tough to sing and it shows the prowess of the singer.

(27:50 - 27:59)

It's very important. So even that even classical music the way it's performed needs to change. It needs to be more immersive.

(28:01 - 28:10)

And that's what we're doing. I have a band called Jalavich and we're also floating an award called Bharat Maestro to find the next Zakir Hussain. Next Ravi Shankar.

(28:11 - 28:30)

Anushka Shankar is there already. For India, we need to find them and then nail them that these are the maestros of India. Like recently I did a song called Muttamalai in Thug Life.

It's a very complicated song. They embraced it so much. Embraced it and it became a talk of for three months they were talking about the song.

(28:31 - 28:45)

Because it has multiple ragas mixing and going in. And if we put our energy and mastery in how we deliver the songs to people, definitely they'll like it. It should not be, you know, I'm giving you classical music listen to it, it's good for you.

(28:46 - 28:57)

No, give something good and make it masterful with the whole team, like the dance and creativity and everything. They will take it. Hey Rama, it's a classical song.

(28:58 - 29:06)

The narrative is how you make them feel. It's the most important thing. Like this decor, it feels very inviting.

(29:07 - 29:41)

It feels very it's welcoming, it feels like somebody is... It feels lived in, right? Yeah, that's very important. It's all from ages old, like those pillars are temple pillars. That door is from a temple chariot.

They're all from South Indian... I think you will also find it familiar because it's largely South Indian stuff. Yeah, I love South Indian stuff. Same with the Peace Garden, if you come to Peace

Garden, if you come to Chennai, I'll take you to which is a combination of South Indian temple architecture, Sufi architecture, mix of all the stuff.

(29:42 - 29:53)

But Indian art seems to be making a comeback. Not enough, I think. No? I think art should be taught, artistic view should be taught to the kids from kindergarten.

(29:54 - 30:59)

The way they keep their houses, if every house in the street is kept well, clean, the street is going to look beautiful. When I went to Italy, that's what I found. Or if you go to Jaipur or Kerala, they have a sense of style which and neatness and... I'm not saying I've not been to many states, but I feel like that's very important to inject that in the minds of younger people who change the look of a country.

Western cities are very homogenous, like every building will have the same colour. That is US. But if you go to places like even Italy, Greece is different, Spain is different, Morocco is different, they all have a character.

Don't you feel like Indian cities have every building which is so different and the colour is so different that it doesn't look cohesive? No, it doesn't. Anyway, let's not talk about that. But important thing is to nurture children from kindergarten.

(31:00 - 31:20)

So, they look at a country in a way where they'll be the future people who will change the way it looks better. Like AI. I think creativity will become more relevant in the world of AI.

Absolutely. Because I think you're empowering people with a vision who don't know the chops. And the chops are actually AI.

(31:21 - 31:47)

So, the vision and the prompts actually gives you options which you see, oh, I like this. And it's a very empowering tool for younger people who don't have the access to make a movie or make art or they know how to paint but they have a vision. At least it will force them to have an example in part of what it's creating to beat that.

(31:49 - 32:01)

Which is an interesting thing now, I think, when you do music also. You're constantly thinking the songs which are coming out are very experimental. Recently there's a song by Ray, R-A-Y.

(32:02 - 32:16)

And it clearly shows that she's trying to beat AI. How is that? The way the construction of the song is different from what people would do. Which what AI copies, right? It's learned from the past.

(32:16 - 32:40)

So, you have to be contrarian to whatever the predictive model is. Absolutely, yeah. It forces us to think differently.

Okay, now we've got that. Okay, how about this? But can't tomorrow another AI just play the role of a contrarian? Humans have this evolutionary spirit and we will do something else. We'll go back and do something which is completely wrong, which will be very cool.

(32:41 - 33:08)

Does music have rules? Music, I feel, I go by nostalgia, I go by the good things of tradition. And sometimes I get bored with that and I break the tradition. So, it's not one formula.

It's like how a narrator, so like when I'm talking to you, if I talk anything boring, you won't look at me. I was like, oh, he's already told us. I'm gonna look away.

(33:09 - 33:29)

But, I'm looking at you, I'm constantly evolving. I'm saying, let me tell you this stuff. Let me tell you a new information which you don't know.

Then you're curious about it. Music is like that. It's like a conversation where one is like, this tune is going like this and I need to surprise them with this one.

(33:30 - 33:40)

Pull out the rhythm or change the key or change the rhythm. Change the raga. Or come with the same lyric in a different way.

(33:41 - 33:45)

So, it is an experience. That's how I used to think. I'm still thinking the same way.

(33:46 - 34:15)

Do you think to be as successful as you have been, you need to catch a counter trend? What is a counter trend? Whenever the incumbent trend, like you said about old school music with dholak and mandolin and all of that. No, I love dholaks. But that's not the only thing.

Even now when I do a Qawwali track, I use dholak and tabla. I use strings. But to be able to

recognize that people are tired of that and I am the people.

(34:17 - 34:26)

I need to see whether I like the song. And if I feel good, this feels really good and they will love it. Sometimes it takes time for them to get it.

(34:26 - 34:49)

They get it and then it stays there forever. And for all the aspiring musicians and songwriters and composers watching this, what do you think the next change in trend will be that they can get on early? I think all of them are so smart now. And because of the exposure, they get to see everything on reels and social media.

(34:50 - 35:16)

Every person is a make-up person, an actor, a cinematographer, a director. And it's fascinating to see how the younger people are evolving. I discover so many people who are extraordinary in comedy, in direction, in effective reels.

It's just 30 seconds and they have to come up with stuff. And it forces them to become great directors, storytellers. And so I get inspired by them.

(35:18 - 35:31)

But any suggestions? Lean into it. Leaning into something, not giving up. You shouldn't give up.

You should go back to music and lean into it. I'll show you how bad I am at some point. No, bad and good is subjective.

(35:33 - 35:40)

One person is bad and the other person is good. You know good music when you listen to it. I'm good at listening to music.

(35:41 - 35:55)

That's a great start. It's a great start. Lean into it.

Just don't give up. Because you dig. The cliche is first you get mud and then you get water, then you get petrol, then you get gold.

(35:55 - 36:04)

But you have to keep digging. And the more you dig, you will forget yourself that you've become that. This is very personal.

(36:04 - 36:20)

I don't know who this will help. I can play a few chords. I don't sing well.

Now I want to suddenly get better. Not suddenly. In a year, get better.

How do I do it? Just practice. Don't wait for tomorrow to practice. Practice now.

(36:20 - 36:26)

Once you go, have to eat. Sit for 5 minutes. Sing slowly.

(36:27 - 36:31)

I've heard it all my life. I don't know why it flew. I have to tell you a secret.

(36:33 - 36:55)

I'm singing from 92. But then my singing was always to compose. I'll play a chord and compose.

Then I realized that when I'm composing, I don't have to be in tune. I just need to understand what tune. When that becomes a habit, your singing becomes more not that perfect.

(36:56 - 37:01)

Because you're trying to reach notes. You're scribbling something. You're sketching something.

(37:02 - 37:08)

Then when I'm on the stage, is when I realized I have to be in tune. Because people are recording. People are putting it on YouTube.

(37:08 - 37:22)

Then I started my teacher said Gulam Sarkar passed away. He said, practice your lower notes. Like Make it stronger.

(37:23 - 37:32)

Your higher notes will be as strong as that. Now I'm learning a little bit from Ajay Chakravarthy. His thing is like go louder when you go down.

(37:34 - 37:43)

That made a lot of difference in my pitch. When I'm singing a note longer, I could feel that I'm in pitch. When I look at some of the reels, I'm like, yeah, that's good.

(37:43 - 37:54)

That's a good 20% improvement from what I was doing before. So, there's no time, no age. We are constantly evolving in every aspect of it.

(37:54 - 37:58)

Maybe I'll try and get a teacher. That's a great idea. And Bombay is filled with teachers.

(37:59 - 38:08)

Yeah? Yeah. Do you think there's such a thing as talent in music? There is. Some people understand something better than other people.

(38:09 - 38:16)

Because it comes the way the mind works. It doesn't mean that other people can't reach that. Right? I have this theory about passion.

(38:17 - 38:35)

I feel like all people are born the same. And we all attempt different things. If I was 5 years old and I played cricket, and I played cricket better than the 20 classmates of mine, I would organically become passionate at cricket.

(38:36 - 38:44)

Because I'm doing it better than the 20 kids around me. Do you think the same is true for music? No. When I was young, I felt I was very bad at music.

(38:45 - 39:10)

I had stalwarts like Madeline Srinivas who was a genius. He was younger than me. He was playing Keerthana.

I said, I'm not as good as that. And I was seeing my teacher's son playing piano, who was younger than me. But I was forced to work anyway.

So my needed talent was less. Because I used to play some sound effects or some simple melodies. And I met a teacher called Jacob John who was my father's friend.

(39:11 - 39:27)

He called me and said, you play very well. I said, no, I don't play very well. And he had this amazing technique.

He would wantedly pay with mistakes and let you play. I said, you're playing better than me. So he had this incredible technique to make you feel better.

(39:29 - 39:36)

And I hung out with him 3-4 years. It was one of the best times I had. I must also say, you look incredibly young for your age.

(39:36 - 39:52)

Like skin is glowing and all that. My software is very very latest but hardware is becoming old. Any secrets? Secrets? Just don't think negative stuff.

Don't worry about anything. Nobody cares. We're all going to die one day.

(39:54 - 40:15)

So all this happened, okay? And then I have notes about different years of your life and what happened. And I'm trying to go into today. You did Andrew Lloyd Webber, Dil Se happened, Vande Mataram India at 50, Maatul Jai Salaam, all of that happened.

(40:17 - 40:27)

We come to 2006. What's happening around this era? You started in 90s because of the studio. When you started a studio, you got this big break in Roja.

(40:27 - 41:11)

Your life changed overnight. People around you started treating you like something else. You got a little imposter complex and insecure about putting all your eggs in one basket because you had seen it happen at home at an early age.

You diversified. You continued to do many things. You went to Andrew Lloyd Webber's thing.

You did things outside of India, in India. Tell us where your mind is at 2006, 2008 around this era. Global slowdown era.

So 2006 I was appointed as the stop TV ambassador by UN. So I went, traveled to Singapore, met AIDS TB patients and a very completely different role. I met Kofi Annan in the UN all that stuff.

(41:11 - 41:49)

And then that's when my foundation, idea of foundation came by. And by this time you were a big deal because you were meeting them. I don't know.

100% Yeah, I don't So I meet them. I come back with a vision of like, why don't we have a school? Like, you know, all these musicians are my father's age now and what if they pass and we don't have string players or trumpet players. So the idea of starting the school came at 2008 where I called one of my associates and said, Hey, we have to start a school.

It's a free school. I'm going to. He said, no, no, no Free school, nobody is going to respect.

(41:49 - 42:08)

You have to get money and I'll be the I'll take care of it. So I didn't know anything. So I called him and he took care of it.

And then there's so many conflicts, so many conflicts happening. It evolved and then finally we bought a bigger place Mr. Ambani came and finally inaugurated the place in 2013. My mother was there.

(42:10 - 1:47:49)

And we started the KM Conservatory where it is now in Chennai. By then we had some of the young, best piano players in the world, young ones. And then it started evolving and then Oscars happened, all this stuff in 2008, 2009 I was in a band with Mick Jagger How big is that? I've always heard of Oscars as being like this crazy ass thing that What is it actually? I think when you see from outside, it's much more fascinating than being inside Inside it's just It's like an award function Once you pass one, then everything is the same Same photographs are coming Hey AR, look here So that's interesting.

First when I got the critics award, nobody called me. Then was the Golden Globe Hey that's you, come let's take a photograph. Three people called Then the next one is Oscar 100 people calling your name So that I could see that whole evolution of how famous that movie and the music and you all becoming How does it make you feel personally? Like now, I'm guessing wherever you are, like people are probably surrounding you and asking you for this and that and pictures No, actually I have a lot of private moments In the studio? No, when you're at home, yes But if you step out? I step out very rarely.

But whenever you do? I'm prepared for it When I'm very uncomfortable is when you take a long 16 hour flight and you're in transit and people come in and they say I'm tired No, but we have to go Can you take a photograph? Anyway, it's part of the game Is there an on-off button? For what? For when some fan walks up to you and you're tired, you're in transit Yeah, it is. But rarely It's not everyday Now I have the mask They recognize you with the mask? No Not everyone. Because I don't go with securities, I just go walk alone No security anywhere? In Chennai? Only when I'm doing shows Because when you don't go with security, people don't take you seriously Only when a group of six people come over Oh, that should be him When you go to dinner in Chennai, for example You have to That is the irony of my life You can't That actually took a toll on

my family life When nobody allows you to eat Even in a marriage, when you go there When you're eating, people say Can I take a photograph? I said, I'm eating No, but we are going to go.

We have to go So they don't understand that person is eating. He's a human being He's not being bought by you But then you understand that how important you are in their life And they don't want to miss the chance To take their perspective So I'd never eat in marriage I just go, wish them, I said They won't allow it. Whenever I've worked with rock stars abroad They're just straight on the face I don't do that, sorry Whether it's a Hollywood actor or I've been with a couple of them They're straight on the face That's why people don't come Because most of them are like that They just snap and say, no, I don't do that Straight away Indian actors are more kind Why is that? I think because we are a different race We did a call with your sister And She gave us some points Which one? Rehana? Yeah, I think so You didn't have many friends growing up, she said Yes, I had two friends actually One was an electronic geek Who used to love making amplifiers Still met him The other one was also an electronic geek I was fascinated with electronics when I was young Is it the same even now? Is it tough to be friends for somebody in your position? There's no time Outside of time? Just even to spend time with family I have to make sure that I now pull them on to a dinner or something Where not everybody is free They all have their own lives now Do you have friends? All the directors are my friends Work people don't count? I don't treat like work I treat like When I work with Anand Rai or MTR People ask me this question And I say, who are your friends? I'll say lawyer, CA, all of that It doesn't add up Then I should have a life where I go to a club No, I go to a gym or something Nothing? No hobbies? Sport? Gym? No Nothing? No I love what I'm doing Because it's not just music now It's metahumans and AI and virtual reality I have younger people who are joining and doing amazing work So they are my friends I just eat with them, hang out with them Each team is different And I sometimes DM people If there's a good person with a farm interesting plantation thing, I DM them Hey, I would like to meet you It's like random people It's not just music It is illustrators and cosplay artists sometimes Anyone incredible you've run across like this? By DMing them? By DM I'm assuming social media The most biggest surprise I got was Spike Lee DMing me.

Hey sir, how are you? Really? DM on what platform? On Instagram You're active like that? You use it yourself? Yeah Can I message you? Of course But I don't pick everything. I see sometimes people I see some... Oh, blue tick What would be interesting for me to send you on Instagram that will make you be like Thanks Nikhil for sending me I have this investor who's got 1 billion dollars to invest in my company I'll be immediately I'll answer You went to the US and met a bunch of AI people, right? Some of them are my friends and they mentioned it. You went to Perplex City You went to... Who was the most interesting of them all? No, actually it's very very brief Sriram and Aarti came to my house and we hung out there and I met Srinivas in Perplex City What did you make of him? He's also from Chennai Yeah, he's very good.

He's my son's friend more than me They hang out and Sam Altman What did you make of Sam? Sam, strangely he was the only person I followed on Twitter for a while when ChatGBD came in

and he was like he was looking at the secret mount and he was fascinated I think that whatever help you guys need in technology right? but I think this is not just secret mount is about fashion merchandise music, wisdom, entertainment quite a lot big package pretty exhausting if you don't have a big team so that's one of the reasons why we are like waiting to for the big leap to which is preparing all the ground work on that one When you hang out with those AI guys I have ended up spending a reasonable amount of time with all of them in fact I have to go My first comment with any AI person is don't make people lose jobs empower people to remove the causes of generational causes which comes to like poverty misinformation and lack of tools to create stuff to telling stories right? I think this is from the beginning I was like a broken record just saying this How is that possible? If you buy a gun you set rules right? You don't give it to everyone because they want to shoot everybody they want to kill people It's not free to use, it has restrictions Like a cabriolet? You are not shooting people but you can pull the carpet off make them jobless It's like making families going into poverty So it is the rules, humans have to set the rules You have traffic rules You have immigration rules While it might kill jobs in the short term one can argue that productivity in a society will go up You have to shape it up You can't give a tool which is very very destructive in making a family go into debt If somebody just learned something and now everything can be done with AI, he is going to be helpless because he has learned that in college for 4 years, he spent all his life learning something and AI can do it in 2 seconds So we need to find an alternate way before you jump and give those tools to people Very tough though No, because Australia now has said like no person can learn use their data to learn so that to create their identity But the new AI's are learning of synthetic data Let it do stuff which humans cannot rather than doing things which humans can do better So that's why I think art plays a very big tool. You need to make musical theatre, symphonies all the stuff which can entertain people and they can be a part of that larger system economic system The problem with regulation around AI in my opinion is the incumbents will use it to not allow new people to come into AI If there is a young kid in Bangalore trying to build an AI wrapper albeit by virtue of regulation he will be regulated out of the market Not that kind of regulation, not in entertainment I'm saying in finding a way all the people running things, entrepreneurs or the chief they should be careful in finding because history is going to talk about them in future like how they made something which is a monster as a blessing. It could become a monster.

It's a blessing and a curse I'm actually going back to the US I've been there a lot this year I've been like working, interning with these AI companies trying to learn what is coming up next, what can be done. I'm going back on Friday Shaken Mountain has also set a pattern where we use the best of AI and we use the best of humans and there will be so many jobs so much of human contribution to something as big as this so that it becomes an industry by itself AI in music will hurt musicians, right? It will hurt but then can AI go and sing with a guitar in a house or in a concert or can it teach in the human way which a teacher has been teaching with the spirit, passing on the spirit of music to a student. There are so many things which comes human experience is the best word I would say which it can't do anything on TV could be generated now, right? So I think that that's why live concerts, live dance live musical theatre, symphonies will be

respected even more right? The value of that is going to go.

So in a way you're saying building more live experiences, businesses for young people who want to start a business. Because we're all now locked in something called the flats imprisoned in those little boxes we can't even get out so live actually gives goes back to that community feeling where you enjoy something with the other person share the experience, the joy and that like that is also being reinvented now live experiences now, the way visuals and everything is time coursing with augmented musical gadgets visual gadgets so the experience is not as like how we watched 10 years back it's much more better now When you work with people and you try and figure out what music should be put out I'm guessing very often you know so much more about music than these people. I don't know anything I go like a blank slate because Like if a movie producer tells you for example say in Hollywood that this is not working can we change it? What do you do? Always change it I don't go with one idea Right.

I go with sometimes four ideas, five ideas then I throw out two of them so I keep sometimes three, I play them and sometimes you have an instinct to say this is going to work I put them somewhere, I think they will connect to something but it's nice but can you do this? Yeah, I'll add that. It's not a ready made product which is given that will never work somebody calls up, I do a song and send it to me the specifics about story, characterization vibe which they like I was reading this book about Michelangelo artist extraordinaire all time whatever and he was like once while he was sculpting David, a politician came to him and said the nose is too big so what he did next is he just, he was on a scaffolding, he threw some dust down and he said he changed the nose but actually he didn't do anything Exactly A lot of that? Yeah, it happens. See now it's correct and you don't know anything It's just their ego.

See, I made it better. Sometimes I was in Delhi couple of days ago and I was at a friend's house and I tried the new meta glasses. Okay, it's coming? It's coming, yeah, which have a so on the right side they have a display and you have to wear a band and then you click like this and you scroll like this For the first time it's starting to feel like it could be the form factor Do you have a bet on what could be the form factor of tomorrow? How you interact with AI? So I started researching on virtual reality around from 2015.

So I directed my first VR movie in 2016 and I was fascinated because it's so real it's so immersive and it helps you to go to places which you've never been like the spaces you can see spaces which Antarctica, you know the Vatican, the Kaaba, the temple where people it's so real right? And I could probably look at one image for more than 5 minutes so many details, so much details So it fascinated and then I said why don't we do I had a story and I said why can't we do a movie in this? This is the path nobody is taking It is a very difficult path Lone Ranger, taking it and walking. So I did Lemask now, it's been almost 9 years since I directed that one It's playing in Singapore and it's playing in Vancouver Dome And you have to wear the VR glasses In Vancouver no, it's projected in the dome It's been translated to So my primary job is of a stock

investor. So I used to follow Meta now, Facebook then, stock for the duration that they attempted to put a lot of money behind the Metaverse They would spend something like 8-9 billion dollars a year if I'm not wrong about the number And eventually they ditched it So does that, they didn't ditch it or they stopped the amount of money that was being spent on it? I think what happened was for making VR movies you need to unlearn many things for content So film people come and use their techniques to do virtual reality It makes people throw up So because I didn't have any experience in film I could take the path of what I felt will be right for for me So like moving the camera would be like nausea Frame rate, global shutter And what kind of experience would be great for a person who is It shouldn't be a replacement for cinema but an alternate co-existing So what you don't get in cinema you'll get on this one In cinema you get the kind of community feel like you all whistle on the same thing, you are all stuck I look at the other person, oh that's a great scene You know that you can't do in VR, it's very personal You can't look at your Facebook, Twitter But you can have other people who are also in VR watching something with you No but this When you come to Chennai, I'll play you my experience, it's installed there You'll understand what I'm talking about Yeah? So I have no agenda today, I don't want to speak about anything I want to speak about what you want to speak about Let me speak about the MetaBand, again This idea came from when I was hanging out in LA after the Oscars, Grammys and all this stuff Why are Indians not creating something for the West? Not the West for the whole world, right? Because we've seen great bands coming from Sweden America England, Africa But the only Indian was famous like Ravishankar Zakir Hussain, Elshankar Subrahmanyam But then why can't young India create something like that? Because we need to be ahead, we can't go back to what they did, but we need to find a space which India, what India wants to say to the world So that's where Secret Mountain was created And not just to sing Hindi songs or Tamil songs But being a voice for, from India to the world Not like an Indian voice, but an international voice Right? So we've been working on it for three years.

Can you simplify it for me? Like, I watched a bunch of videos of you talking about it Yeah. I saw the characters who are the band members The blonde guy The Punjabi guy, all of them And they all said that my proficiency is in A and B And we are a band. But what does that mean really? It talks about each community, where they're coming from Like Africa, North India, South India, Ireland.

She was the prettiest the African. Yes, we made sure that we gave her the full respect Especially Africa, Ireland India, China They have millions of stories to tell, but there's no conduit for that. But now they're virtual, they're now mentors for each character So we're going like, this is what we want to say Is it okay? Politically This is the kind of lyrics which I couldn't come And the lyricists, they're I'm composing all the stuff, but then we have partners like people like Ed Sheeran had promised to write songs for us He was hearing a couple of songs I love this, I want to do something So these are virtual characters You are the mentor for say one virtual character amongst Mentor for the whole band All of my digital children And they will create songs? They won't create songs So they're human people Like in a movie, a James Bond movie comes in

James Bond is a character People keep changing, but James Bond is constant Superman is constant, Spiderman is constant So these people will be constant? Exactly.

They'll be constant. The voices might change Because they're all live voices Live musicians Live musicians are going to play with it So it's not AI created content, composition or anything It's all live Only the face of that Right They won't have flesh and blood But what's going to appear on TV Or in a show Will be real Because of the technology Hologram And why would this be better than say Ed Sheeran is writing a song for one of those characters Him singing it himself And having his face on it Because this is a multicultural band They stand for the whole world Yeah There is no band like this Either you see a K-pop band, we're all Koreans An English band, we're all English And very rarely you see This kind of eclectic, diverse band Coming together Right And me being not in just one genre Of stuff, and film music has taught me To be expansive Right So I felt like taking the burden on myself To see how much I can go Dwell in it, making it pop I'm not able to picture it Do you think an audience will I mean the same premise I guess in a way Applies to movies Did you see the Abba Voyager Yeah, the hologram right Yeah, so this is Probably a diverse version And maybe 7th generation of that Right That was created 7 years back This is today's technology Was that kind of playing on memory Because everybody kind of Yeah, but then being a songwriter And I just tested all the songs I was testing all the songs I was trying to see whether they liked the music or not So all kinds of Nationalities like people from America, England, Ukraine And it tested very well At least 4, 3 to 4 Songs tested like, I like this They didn't mention the same song They mentioned 4 different songs So I felt like, okay we're on a good track And end case, what will be Happening with this They will be performing They could also perform in 3 different places too At the same time, omnipotent Because They're virtual, right, they could be performing In England, in India, in Dubai All at the same time Different teams can come in And they could become a series They could become a movie Have you seen NFTs Yes This kind of like It started like that, it started like In a way when Hedara came too It started like, can we do Crypto, NFT kind of thing I said like, we need a bigger idea The bigger idea is this And let other stuff Come from here Because even if that goes off like a fad This will stay, the music will stay The vision of this band Stays, and what they're going to say So it's a solid Idea, so that's one of the reasons Why even after 3 years we're all excited about it And every inch we Move towards getting it Out, we feel like Because it's evolving When we started It was a game engine, Unreal Engine and MetaHumans Now we have AI technology Which enhances the face Enhances, not generative But face swapping And all the stuff which might Used to take a long time Even the capture is much faster You can cleanse the capture Sometimes you have some stutters With these costumes I can send you all the footage Tomorrow if there was a movie With say Shahrukh Khan and a particular Actress Not really them But artificially Generated movie, would you watch it? There are so many movies like that You don't even know Half the movie is 100% of the movie, it depends on the story Don't do what What Shahrukh Khan will do Well, you don't try to imitate that That would be mediocre Of this band They have to do things which only they can do They have the super power To do the stuff So that is important, because I've seen a lot of people Use AI Generate a TV serial Which is, you know TV serial actors can do better than What this

generates, but you do stuff Which will be impossible for Production or to finance Or to act And give that experience Which is transformative Once you've been able to articulate An expression and voice and Program it in, long term These AI characters Will inevitably They are not AI characters They are real characters It took 9 months to illustrate, get the nose The eyes, the smile and everything No, but these characters will always do better Than real world humans No, that's I'm the founder of that So, I determine And I've set the rules, the parameters For what, how much it can talk How much money it can send to each fan All this stuff will be set by Our team, the founders Why would it send money to a fan? That's a secret So, just to be like I think if they make money The band makes money Why can't they share the money with people who deserve And so that is the whole ultimate plan That they benefit Not just by watching it But that is the whole By going to things Which Humans might be corrupted But with the kind of For transparency which Systems can run And do all the checks and balances It is possible I know people have attempted this with Social media where super users Yeah Got a percentage of the traction or the revenue That the social media platform earned overall So here you are saying Because the success of the character Is dependent on the Amount of traction which in turn Is dependent on the fan And you would share a part of the revenue That is the plan And in future So you become the platform which collects In the future even the website Will have all six of them You can talk to each of them This is not a real human Answering back though No, the parameters are set by All the data, all the Information or all the wisdom Which each character wants to Which comes from mentors Which comes from the research of What does an Africa An African person Want the world to hear What is the unsaid Narrative about that Or what does a North Indian wants to What a South Indian I just put that because it is We are different Punjabi is different from a Tamil guy, right And extremes, North and South And a Chinese person An Irish person You have great history The great history in every character And you would scrape news to Figure out bias and narrative No, it is just a From a common perspective And a middle ground, I think when you look at things There are a lot of unfair things which has happened to many Many races Undeniable And even if you look at The genocide in Africa Which has happened, which is more than Any other genocide in the world It is unfortunate but The world It is not a political band They are not going to do political stuff But I feel the gravitas of that is very important For A band coming from India Which is just, which is Pure in thinking Which is entertaining First of all, not boring Would it speak about society? Of course. But when you speak about society You become political I think you will find the balance AI will help There is this interesting Debate happening in the US now Where If I am the New York Times I am the editor of the New York Times If a journalist Writing an article under the New York Times Says something which is defamatory I am liable The same question then Starts to apply for a large language model Absolutely.

If the output They are throwing out, are they liable? So much of responsibility They claim not. No, but that is why We have to set the parameters Very important Sometimes you can't say the truth Just keep quiet I think because it is music And because it is about Entertainment, we don't have to go into that stuff Unnecessary Conflicts It is very important to entertain in a way where People

get hope And faith Someone said A passion Ceases to be a passion When you truly Understand it The good thing about music is you never understand it It is constant evolution That is why they say If you paint with the right Hand constantly And you get comfortable with it Tie your right hand And paint with the left hand But then you will find a different way Because your mind wants to express And the limitation of what Your left hand is Will make its own art And it won't be like The comfort zone. Oh, I can't do that so I will do this And that will be different So music is also like that.

Sometimes you just have to Throw all the formulas I have to rethink, I have to see I have to get there, but I don't want to go This route I will go on this route Because you are the first listener The maker is the first listener Like the cook is the first taster, right? Whenever I cook food You don't taste it? No, because I don't know what it is Like whenever I spend Half an hour, 45 minutes making something I am Inherently biased into liking what I have made Because of the opportunity Cost of time that has been invested You are less Judgmental Or critical of No, I am very critical When I Listen to it a couple of days later Or a week later You know what's working, what's not working What makes you Oh, I love that. Oh, this is boring. I have heard this before I do a curation And then Whichever thing I like, sometimes I don't like anything I go back to the Drawing board But how do you prioritize Something like that where It's not what is Earning you your wage But to focus on it enough To not give up? I think what happens when you do something Constantly You get fatigued Your mind becomes tired And in this case where Photography or anything else Poetry or It's all part of the creative industry It's not like gambling or Going away from something, losing money It is enhancing your Widening your imagination Widening Your confidence in you That you can do much more Are you still able to do that? Pick up new hobbies? Yeah Something which doesn't Involve the display Because all my life I have been sitting in front of a display So that's one of the reasons I don't play video games PlayStation or Xbox and all that stuff Because I don't want to sit in front of a And I wanted to try something organic So I'm Might go into farming a little bit more Are you farming now? Yeah, we have a Mom's plot, the trust plot Near the house? It's one hour from Chennai That's where her samadhi is also there Okay, this is on the work side Tell us what's going on in the Personal side By personal I don't mean like some Controversial thing or anything like that Where is your headspace at? How are you looking at Society? At music? What is occupying your mind? I think what's beautiful about the past I would say 18 years Is starting the foundation Starting the music school And watching miracles happen there You know, kids Demolishing the Whole stigma Saying that this caste is Intelligent, this caste is not Demolishing all the stuff Any kid who is created by God The light of God is in every kid And the knowledge comes From God, it's not that They are worthy or not, if they're taught Properly and we find those kids They shine, they become an orchestra And they all play together as one voice As one emotion So that's what we discovered And it's a phenomenal breakthrough Which we are proud as a family My sister runs the school, I go there I'm the mentor, I'm the principal And then recently went to Canada For the Glenn Gold Foundation They invited us And we all played It's such a great moment to see Kids from corporations Taking a flight, going to Canada And playing for You know, billionaires sitting there And that itself Is a great statement

and that keeps me going If I'm the principal of that Kind of kids, I need to be shining more I need to be working more And that keeps me going People ask me what keeps you going Is that I need to inspire my School children, my students Where we are teaching Incredible Artistry, right? To sing or to play the piano To compose To inspire Do you think humans can innately be Altruistic? Selfless? It is how we were brought up I've seen many people Many families Any religion If they are coming from a great family If the fathers and mothers are Selfless and they act upon it And they create a kind of system Where the kids Automatically get inspired, they look up to their Father and mother.

If you go one level Deeper Why is being selfless appealing? I think It is hardwired Like if you look at Every spiritual Teaching in the world is to serve Only when you serve Somebody served and built you this house Somebody served and built The road and they might Be dead but their soul is there In every... Did they do it with the intent of service or Did they do it with the intent of Individual gain that they were Chasing? Of course, everybody needs to run the family But when you think About... You can see the sweat You can see the... Everybody wants their work to shine When they want their work to excel Excel is not mediocrity Right? Sincerity is very important Sincerity is what makes them tick Get them another job If I am not sincere in my music They are going to throw me out Right? I think you are way beyond that No, I am just saying Nobody, anybody can be thrown Anybody can cease to exist It is... Because if I am not sincere to that thing I am not sincere to myself I won't be able to sleep If I let a mix pass by Or a song which could be better And I didn't work enough for that That will be the biggest punishment or self-torture For me For at least 3-4 months I should have done that better So, I never give that chance For my mind to torture me Even at the cost of Getting a bad name from the producer So, I'll Share a secret. I was going through some I would not say bad time But I would say I was feeling vulnerable Because of some issue Being blamed for something that I didn't have anything to do with And I was sitting and thinking about all these things When I have been Altruistic Is it Because the projection of altruism Has appeal Because in the society that If I go back in time When I think about it All men Are competing With each other at some level The hunter-gatherer The biggest hunter got more Validation and importance in the society That he was in So, everybody wanted to be the biggest hunter at that time And I think with evolution Society has kind of progressed like that In the capitalistic Society The projection of being Selfless Is a value add So I think we are spiritually oriented If you believe in God There is only one creator We call them in different names So, if I take That path I respect everybody I have taken that path Where I feel like every breath is a blessing To me Every opportunity is a blessing to me And it comes from one source It comes from me surrendering That I don't have to worry I will be truthful I'll, you know I'll remember you And he remembers me And if my share Which he wants to give Has to come to me Even if the whole world is against it, it's going to come to me Right And if I don't deserve something And if I want that, if it's not my share It will never come to me So, it's simple to be peaceful I take this as a formula So, there is no cause of jealousy If somebody is in a better car In a better house I said, his share His share is coming It's great I love it, I praise God for that And

may he live happy So, you don't have the root of jealousy Is now killed And if I need to be If I need something like that My worthiness has to be improved Once I'm worthy Suppose I'm going to get 100 kgs I need to handle it, I need to take it Otherwise it's going to destroy me I've seen many people Be given something which is very valuable And that has destroyed their whole lives Because they're not able to take that much So, each one gets What they share by becoming Worthy of it Become the vessel, empty vessel And become cleaner And then you'll get all the gift I think Over years, you'll realise that one Oh, I didn't get that project I'm not famous in this area So, you become worthy, you'll get Do you feel like that? You are probably One of the proudest Sons of our country ever No, I'm just saying Sometimes we're human, right? Oh, that music is selling well It crossed 2 billion streams I was like, fine Right So, my share is always coming to me And I'm working for it And each day I'm trying to become worthy Of something else I know you Follow Islam Mostly Sufism My Quest to religion was More spiritual Because I've been I'm a fan of all the religions I've studied Christianity Hinduism, Islam I think every religion has something beautiful About it But I also keep trying to figure out The intricacies of What Makes one religion different from another And why one works Depending on the Era that it lives in My problem is killing people In the name of religion Or harming people or abusing people In the name of religion It's not cool for me I feel like It is a tool to discover Greater things And we have to go Which is the core of humanity And that's one of the reasons why I love music I love to entertain I think when I perform, I feel like it's a shrine We're all Enjoying the fruits of Oneness In a stadium You don't even know Some people believe, some people don't believe They come from different nationalities, different languages But one sound and one happiness And one ecstasy Which is beautiful That's what the Wonderment Tour is about Can you tell me more about Sufism? I'm very interested Sufism is Somebody give me two books to read about this The simple thing is to discover yourself How do you discover yourself? Because you have screens Your true self is Screened And to remove those screens You have to perish So when you perish You become a part of The light You're saying when you're alive, perish, take out ego in a way Yeah, so It's like dying before dying What is death? The death of lust The death of greed, the death of jealousy The death of judgment A bit like Buddhism? No, this is different When you remove everything The drop mingles the ocean There's no drop, there's no ocean Metaphorically So we are all in the process We know some people achieve it early And when they achieve it early, they go off They pass off So when that happens Your voice becomes the voice of God Your deeds become the deeds of God Your sight becomes The sight of God So Your ego is gone And then you become transparent To the divine So this is the main essence of it So when you say Auliyas Saints Like Haji Ali Sahib or Khawaja Sahib So they've Achieved that status And when you go to a place like that You don't worship them You go in a place where they're surrounded with Spiritual beings Like angels Who are praying constantly because that place is blessed So when you pray there It's effective much more To God than in a normal place Same with the temple It's like a gathering Like if you go in a place where intelligent people are It sticks to you You get the knowledge Like energy you believe in Like if you go to a temple which has Like Tirupati I go every year You do feel a certain way Yeah, that's the secret of every spiritual place And uneniable Every spiritual

place? Yeah, if people are going there There's a blessing there There's honesty The commonality of faith is what I love Like you might be in a different religion I might be in a different but the sincerity of the Faith is what Is measured I feel That's what makes you do good things That's what makes me do good things Not that I'm worshipping a God who's different Right? So I might build a school, you might build a school But everything is Benefited, humanity is benefited by that So I heard you say in another interview Karma Karma, this is leading towards karma As the answer I think In the belief of Sufism or In Islam In Islam You're judged by Your deeds Right? Not by how much money you have What car you have Or how famous you are But your deeds So that's why we're all spiritual We call us fakis, spiritual beggars We might be rich in money But poor in spirituality And that's one of the reasons why I consider myself as a Spiritual beggar So I go to I sit near the beach or meditate Just to get Spiritually rich And spiritual richness comes in And material richness follows If you need it, if you don't need it, it's fine And then there is The aura which comes to you Which is a blessing So your work becomes successful What you do with intention Becomes more Appreciated I would say I ask everybody what is spirituality Some people tell me They ask me if I am spiritual I don't even know what it means What does spirituality mean to you? The good deeds, being kind To serve humanity And to be respectful to your Parents, to your neighbours Is that morality or spirituality? It is spiritual These are all part of Sharia Smiling is a part of Sharia Smiling at someone is the biggest Sharia If you don't have money to give, let me smile at them You know So the beauty of I mean I am just a student I am not an expert in anything Don't take me seriously I am constantly trying to Imbibe and I don't read stuff I want to experience things and then I realise Okay that's true I don't read something and believe something This is what it says and I believe in it But I want to knock at a door I should get an answer Whether it's music or spirituality And that's how my life is I test out everything Even music When they say something is good Everybody says oh that's a hit song Listen to it, if it's not good enough for me I throw it out It has to do something to my heart It has to do something to my soul And that's why I don't care When some of my songs fail I know it's going to come back And three years later, what a song Yeah I knew it So that self validation is very important To find, believe in your work And find why it is So in a way you want to give more than you take If all scales were balanced Music is giving And I am getting so much love from people I am so I feel worthless most of the time Do I need this? Do I deserve this? Makes you work harder When I think of Indians I think of Politics There is one person who comes to mind I think of cricket Maybe Sachin and Virat come to mind I think of Artists, acting wise Maybe, I don't know, Amitabh Bachchan Somebody like that comes to mind When I think of music Not I, when the country thinks of music You come to mind They say that It's easy to be godlike If you get the validation And devotion that comes With Being known as god It's much harder for A normal person To be godlike by virtue of that So who is the god? You are known as the god I mean god of music In this domain for sure I am such a big fan Your song Tu Hi Re I think I must have heard that song Through so many Heartbreaks Falling in love and stuff like that Maybe you wrote it for a completely Different reason What happened was Mani wanted He wanted a love song I was like what love song? I was so famished and I was sleeping And then this tune was coming to my mind

It's so slow So anyway it's coming It's like coming in my dream I used to have a tape recorder Like a mini cassette, so I just recorded it And So next day I was like where is the tune? I got the sound tune It's okay, let's record Then we recorded it And so for the Singers I wanted SPB or J Siddharth So I put also Hariharan's name And then I picked I don't do that anymore So I prayed and picked one It had Hariharan's name So Hari is a very very unusual singer for that song Why is that? Because he is a ghazal singer And even now when he sings concerts He doesn't stand on a note Because that's his style So we recorded it and then Mani shot it Then he called up He said AR, this song is doing something I just put it on it and it's magic I think we need to do a BGM You know when she is running Then we added all that music So it had an interesting history Incredible song, love that song But now that you are on this In this space, like you are essentially God to all of us No no no, I am a servant only How does that make you feel? It's a double edged sword It's like they say There is no fame Without blame It just takes one second for people to Completely turn the coin So I don't take it seriously I am sincere to what I believe in And Even if I shout at people I say sorry guys I am human right, sometimes the pressure I shout at people You don't look like somebody who can shout at people I come to my studio Not always You seem like you have a very calm I am calm most of the time But for me, my work sincerity It demands a lot of If something is not happening Then I am failing myself and failing the client When was the last time you shouted at somebody And for what? Yesterday No just because it's a very demanding work Right Suppose we are having 77 tracks And you want the strings to be loud Or even EQing the strings I need speed Musicians are passionate You don't want somebody to take 30 minutes to get something Which I think could just take One minute Is that what irritates you? Something taking longer than it should? No, I am just saying My voice will be louder The dynamics will be forte Not pianissimo In musical language They say What are you looking forward to at this point? What are you scared of And what are you looking forward to? Scared of? All the scary things have already happened in my life My father's death My grandmother's death My mother's death And I am looking forward And does it affect you in that order? It did It made me completely numb It made me zen mode It made me believe that everybody is going to die So it kind of Catching on to something And loving something Deeply Is a Unfortunately Anti-spirituality As a loving The true love is a love for God Every other love is tested And when you say God, you are in a way saying universe The creator The creator So I think we can learn from everything From the plant, from the sea, from the mountain From the sky, from the bird From microorganism Is that where your music is most inspired by? Nature? Absolutely Also mathematically The enormity of And the complexity of every creature Every creation And in the galaxy Not even a dot And the multiple galaxies Makes you humble How small you are How The micro and macro Do you also look at that technically? Like in my world of trading we have Fibonacci sequences The golden ratio And try to find that in music Or create music with that I just go by instinct What will be interesting And what will be a good combination of things And What are you most looking forward to? I am looking forward to the success of Secret Mountain If it deserves Because we are putting all our hard work We want to create something Extraordinary from India to the world And Because we put Three years of our life in it We want to make this The most significant Entity from India to the world Are

you bored of movies? No, I am never bored Because you know If a western artist Has to do an album, they have to think about it I am getting help from the script From the director, from the screenwriter From the lyricist My part is just music, right? So each album is different because The different Combination of different consciousness comes together And we create With the intention of creating something great We push ourselves into And then we have live feedback Each song How it's received and how people So that magic has not changed At all, like what you get from people That instant feedback and The adulation in the concert Is a great thing I never want to lose that And if I want to do anything, like I want to do a Private album Instrumental album or collaborative album I am free to do it Nobody is stopping me The big project right now is Ramayana? There is Ramayana There is so many Sacred Mountain And Couple of English ones Going on And an Arabic movie A horror movie Called Bab Namith showed me parts of Ramayana It looks incredible Yeah Look, sounds incredible Thank you Do you think there is a future to the movie business? The movie theatre business? Theatre business is not going anywhere It's going to stay but it should be reinvented Can you tell me how? Because over 100 years now We are still seeing a rectangle screen And of course some 3D And all the stuff comes in I think immersive thing is the future Like The Spear, what's doing in Vegas Everything looks so Unbelievably spiritual And It's something very human about Watching with that quality I have never been there but I have seen the videos It is incredible I think that's the future Because you can never get that in home Entertainment or A phone or anything Experience that kind of It's incredible So you are saying everybody can afford a big screen Not everybody but a lot of people can afford a big screen at home So the difference between A rectangle in your house and the rectangle In a movie theatre Can't just be 10X the size It has to be a bunch of other things Especially now because Now that we have been bombarded with Content I hate that word That you need to reinvent The way movies are made Together So that they don't go to that It's boring, I know what's going to happen So let me look at Instagram me or What's happening So that goes away because you are all stuck Completely involved All the senses are active In Le Musk We have scent, we have haptics, we have motion We have 3D We have ambisonic sound All the stuff comes in together And that's a different experience But can a theatre screen afford that? That's not our problem When people make money They would have to invest more money Even each metro can have one Right And we don't even have A proper symphony hall in any of India Nowhere And musical theatre is another Important Aspect of entertainment Which could come in because we have so many talented Singers, actors here And they are all looking at movies And if you look at London West End Or Broadway Or Canada or Australia They have musical theatre and it travels Once you make one big hit It travels all over the world forever For like years, 40 years, 50 years It's there Look at Sound of Music or Phantom of the Opera We have great stories to tell And I've seen When I was a kid I've seen Parashuram, Ravaneshwaran And That's it Now I think the only one which I keep Seeing is Moghul Yasin Nothing else significant in India I went for the Phantom Premiere at NIMACC Incredible And that's probably the only place Which is world class in India Is it a chicken and egg problem? Because the discretionary spending Power of Indian audience Is limited to a certain number Can you just think about an airport Oh the airport is

very costly Let's go on trains. You can't.

It's a necessity For people They have a right to Have proper infrastructure. It's very important There should be enough Places which brings hope Pride Entertainment If you don't Deliver that, they take a flight and go to Germany, watch Hans Zimmer and Phantom of the Opera in London and they come And oh that's so great. Like what about the Person who can't afford that.

They don't deserve that They also deserve to see You are influencing minds Which can become the next Einstein or Ramanujam or you know Steve Jobs This is the way you should inspire them They don't need to see that Only in America or England Our country is now prosperous enough It's important to Be in a chorus to say that We need this This is for future India, for our youth, for our children To experience all this If you were to give some advice So our audience I'm not good at advice Our audience Is largely wannabe Entrepreneurs, young From India Who want to know what business to start, what Company, what startup In the live event space Like there's bookmyshow There's district, there's a couple of Concert organisers If you could advise our audience To start a business in live It's growing the fastest In terms of rate of growth versus Other form of entertainment What could somebody start? Simple thing Finding the void I find Void in art Artistic stuff Fashion Fashion is taking, I mean Definitely coming, like it's much better now But even furniture Like this furniture You have here, you can't buy it Nobody makes it They make something very boring It's copy pasted from 100 years back There's no imagination in Any kind of furniture which I see It comes from Indonesia Or China or Malaysia I see a void there It's because of scale that China Has in producing these But we should have scale We have more population than China But they're producing for the world So they get the cost Who's asking not to export? And electronics We still don't have Like my keyboard I wish I play An Indian keyboard in my lifetime No, it's from Japan or US or Germany or London Never from India Musical theatre of course In my thing definitely Musical theatre, having an orchestra in every State is very important Having a world class, like a sphere Kind of a thing, changing Entertainment, entertainment is something which people Need, people would But if a sphere costs 500 million dollars to build No, I don't think so, everything is so slashed up Like all the LEDs you get so cheap now I mean at that time maybe It would have costed that much money Not anymore you think? Not anymore, I think definitely With the latest technology as much It's probably one hundredth of the Price now And you don't need that big a sphere Would that be something if somebody Comes with a very interesting business pitch To build One of our young friends Would you be interested in partnering? Bring them in, we'll create the content for that We'll create everything Right Okay, I mean I have no Questions per se left, last part Anything else you want to say Fleeting thoughts About the world Society What are What is occupying your mind Space that You're actually thinking about? I stopped seeing the news literally from 2000 2001 After the war Smart man, I think most people should stop Sometimes I forget and go into Streaming and I see and then I get sick So I think the best Choice for anybody is to look At your own family, your own welfare Your own parents, your kids And be kind to your friends My neighbours And because if you Think about the world, what's going to happen to the world You miss what is going to happen to your

family If you look after your family, the world will take care of itself Makes sense I think even back in the day, the world was going through Problems, it's just today we're seeing Now we're seeing everything like this close Yeah, so every problem looks like Big, yeah like now we're wondering Why is some crime Happening in some corner of Africa, I'm sure It was happening 50 years ago, absolutely Not that we are insensitive about it I think we just definitely have to Develop a great justice system, socially Right, but it's important Not to get disheartened and Lose your faith in humanity Because you are humanity, each one of us Is humanity, our good and bad Affects humanity, it's very important Okay, thank you so much For doing this, would you like to finish with a song Is it possible? I'll send you a clip If I give you a guitar, would you like to I don't play guitar much I can play if you sing, if you tell me what chord to play Wow I don't know what, I'm in the Talking mode now You can do one minute, it'll look really nice Just bring that guitar from my bedroom Bedroom guitarist Bedroom guitarist Give me the, okay, it's in tune It's in tune I think Should be in tune, I'll play a chord, you tell me If it sounds in tune Play a minor chord What chord is that? A minor And go to E major So, A minor, E major Okay Okay? So go to E minor Go on just to A minor And then I'll change Thank you That was fun I'd love to come one day and sit in your studio And you're making a song I'll sit quietly in a corner I'll sit quietly in a corner I have a studio here too In Bombay? Yeah, Andheri, big complex When are you making a song next? Today, tonight Really? You wanna go make a song now? What do you sing?